Graphic Design

Creative Thinking

Summary Notes

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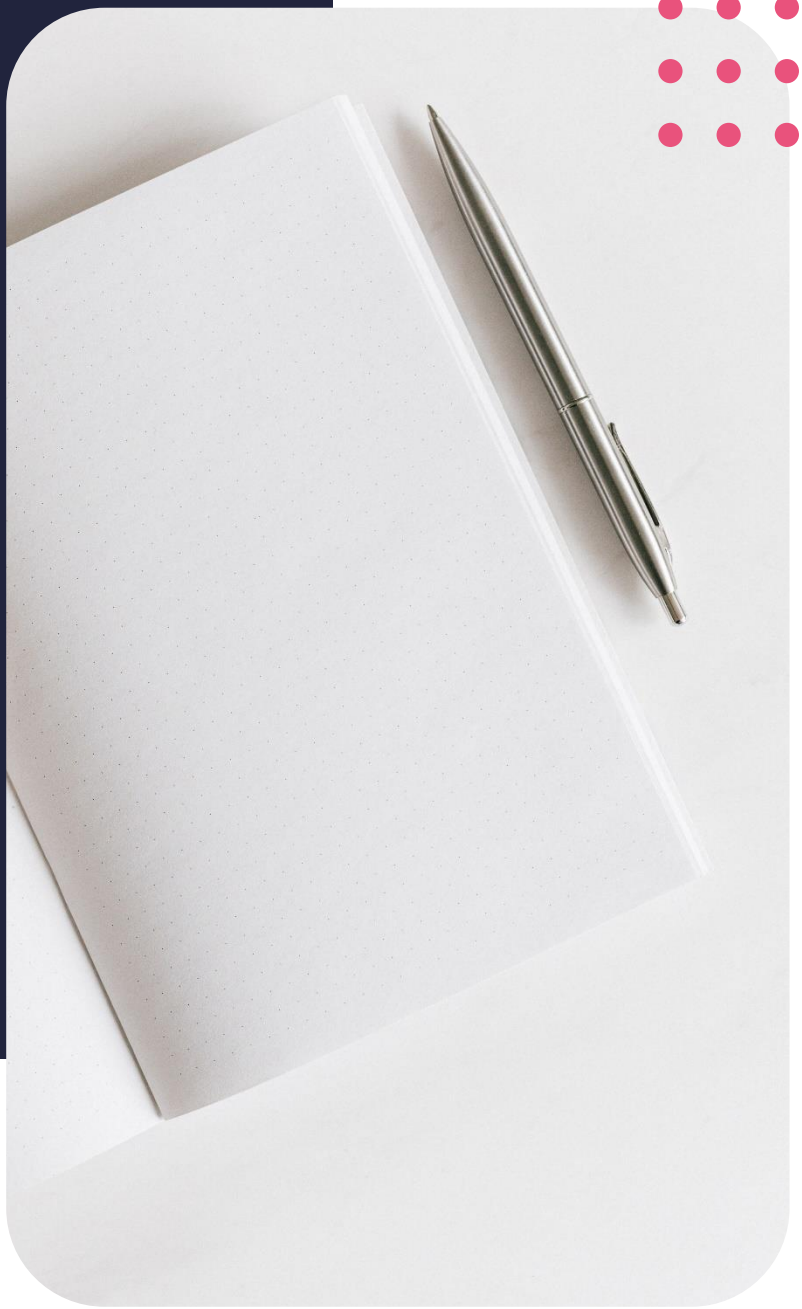


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

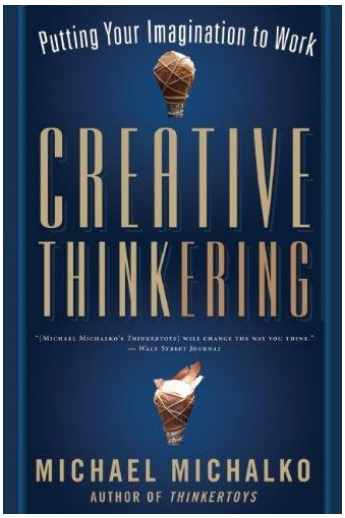
- Lesson outcome 1: What is creativity
- Lesson outcome 2: Creativity in graphic design
- Lesson outcome 3: Structured imagination & conceptual blending
- Lesson outcome 4: Incubation effect
- Lesson outcome 5: Idea generation in graphic design
- Lesson outcome 6: Steer clear of niches

Introduction

Before we officially start with our lesson, I want you to get a piece of scrap paper and pen or pencil ready for a brief exercise we will be doing in a couple of minutes – it is crucial that you do this with me for your own good, so bear with me.

Did you know that creative ideas are more likely to appear when you are not focusing on the task at hand? Have you ever gotten that "eureka" moment in the shower, or perhaps one night you woke up to this amazing idea? The problem was that you were under the impression that you would remember what you thought of the next morning, but then forgot. So, when that creative idea strikes, make sure that you have your phone's digital note pad or a pen and paper handy to write it down. There is a reason why we get these ideas when least expected, and I will explore this topic with you during this lesson.

The quote I am sharing today is quite long but worth it. Taken from author Michael Michalko, who is an expert in the field of creative thinking. A lot of the content I am sharing with you in this lesson is based on his findings. If you are interested in the process of creative thinking, I'd suggest you invest in his book Creative Thinkering. This book opened my mind to so many possibilities and during this lesson, I hope that I can do this same for you.



Michael Michalco: Creative Thinkering

Michael states that: "Creativity is paradoxical. To create, a person must have knowledge but forget the knowledge, must see unexpected connections in things but not have a mental disorder, must work hard but spend time doing nothing as information incubates, must create many ideas yet most of them are useless, must look at the same thing as everyone

else, yet see something different, must desire success but embrace failure, must be persistent but not stubborn, and must listen to experts but know how to disregard them.“

A lot said, but what does it mean? Essentially, it means that a lot of what creativity is, is based on existing knowledge but that you should not make a habit of that knowledge. In other words, forget what you know but embrace your experiences. As contradicting as this may seem, the more you let your mind explore creativity, the more this will make sense.

Activity

Draw an alien

So, having your pen/pencil and scrap paper ready, I would like you to draw what you think an alien should look like. Please don’t be pedantic on your drawing ability here, as this is not what I am evaluating now. Keep your drawing as we will examine them a bit later. I will also show you a couple of drawings my fellow colleagues have done, so don’t worry – you’re not the only one doing this.

What is creativity?

Kicking off, we will need to look at defining creativity first. According to your knowledge what does it mean to be creative?

You might say that it is the process of “thinking outside of the box” but what does this mean? What does it actually mean to “think outside of the box”? Who came up with the phrase?

Perhaps you can argue that it means to think in a different way than the masses normally do. To come up with a totally new concept that has never been done before or maybe to show expression, be original or to create random ideas. Some might argue that this thing we call creativity is a gift that only certain individuals are blessed with – you either have it or not; that these special individuals simply come up with awesome ideas because that have a gift for being creative.

Well, let’s investigate this process of creativity and try to define it.

According to the Cambridge university’s dictionary, creativity can be defined as “the ability to produce or use original and unusual ideas”. Which might not be far from what you had in mind.

Getting all philosophical: when do we need to be creative? Have you ever thought about when it is necessary to be creative and why it is so necessary?

Think about this – being creative in whichever way you can possibly think, all have one thing in common – can you think about this one thing that all creative ideas that have ever been invented have in common?

The one commonality that all creative ideas or inventions started with was to solve a problem. So, all ideas and inventions emerged from a problem that had to be solved.

Let’s look at an existing example to make things a bit clearer: If you’re not familiar with Louis Braille, he was the inventor of the Braille writing system for the blind.

Does this look familiar to you? Well, yes, this is what Louis Braille, who invented the Braille system that is almost unchanged since its design during the 1820's.

What is the point I am trying to make with this? It is the fact that Louis Braille, being blinded due to an accident when he was very young had a problem he needed to face. He was not able to read. This led Louis to the invention of the braille reading and writing system for the blind.

Since Louis Braille was confronted with a problem, he figured a way to solve this problem. So, being faced with a problem, will initially either stir us creatively, or we can turn away from it and look the other way. Eventually, what you do with this problem, is your responsibility and choice.

Creativity in graphic design

So, how does this concept of problem-solving and creativity link up with graphic design? Well, since graphic design is a creative field, it seems as though creativity plays a huge part in what makes a successful graphic designer of course.

Considering what graphic design is and what you have learnt in previous lessons, you will recall that graphic design is about creative problem solving. So, technically, creativity should be a must for every graphic designer.

My next question will then be that whether you consider yourself to be creative? Do you believe that you are creative? You might sometimes feel like you are not creative but take heart that it is a process we can learn. So, don't lose heart!

I will repeat myself – creativity is a process that can be learnt and with more exposure to things and people that stir you creatively, the more creative you will become.

If you keep telling yourself that you are not creative, then you deny yourself the opportunity to be creative. Whether you think you can or can't, either way, you are right. As soon as you deny yourself the opportunity to believe, your thinking dies, and you will not try come up with a solution. Hence, you are the only person standing in your own way of being truly creative.

Activity

Draw an alien 2

I would like to go back to your alien that you drew. Considering that most of us have never seen an alien, what does your alien look like?

Let's look at what some of my colleagues created and perhaps you can compare your drawing to theirs.

Does your alien have hands and/or feet? Does it have a face with eyes or a mouth? What about antennas or tentacles? Maybe your alien has only one eye or more than two eyes. It might have more than five fingers or less than five (if it has fingers). It might have arms, legs and a body.

Perhaps your alien does not have any of these features and rather have amphibian like hands and or feet or look more like a creature you get in the deep oceans.

Have you ever seen an alien? I'm sure most of you would say no. I certainly have never encountered an alien. So, how do you know what an alien looks like if you have never seen one? What is the conclusion we can make with this exercise?

Structured Imagination & conceptual blending

It is the phenomenon called structured imagination. Structured imagination is the tendency to rely on your existing knowledge to be creative.

Now, considering this, ask yourself the following questions: If aliens were to exist, how do you know that they have mouths? Do aliens need to eat like we do, or breathe like we do? Do aliens need to see like we do. Who says that aliens move around like we do – do they need hands and feet? Even if your alien did not have most of these elements or features, it certainly resembled something you have encountered before.

The point I'm trying to make is this: don't punish yourself for not coming up with this unthought of idea – this idea that has never been thought of before. It is almost impossible. And if you do come up with something that seems totally absurd or different – you were probably also inspired by something. Hence structured imagination will always play a role.

This brings me to my next question. How can we stimulate creativity then? If creativity relates to original or unusual ideas, how do we foster it?

The answer lies in conceptual blending. Conceptual blending relates to the norm of combining existing unrelated ideas or concepts with each other to create a new novel idea or concept.

Let's take an example: remember Louis Braille that created the Braille writing system for the blind? Did you know his initial though took place at a very young age when a friend handed him a pinecone? What does a pinecone have to do with braille reading? Well, the texture of the pinecone gave him the idea to conceptually blended this with the process of reading.

So, as soon as you take two or more existing unrelated concepts and combine them, your idea will seem novel and might creatively solve a problem in a different way than others might think of.

Therefore, it is a good idea to have interests in other fields as it allows your brain to make novel connections.

After briefly explaining the concept of conceptual blending to my colleagues, I asked them to redraw an alien. I'm sure you're interested to see what they came up with…

By simply applying the process of conceptual blending, which I literally explained to them in 3 minutes, this is what they came up with. The ideas were drastically different and did not resemble aliens from movies they have watched but rather their own version of what they think an alien can be.

To come up with an original idea, you don't have to be first, you just have to be different and better.

If you think about the various creatives through the centuries, from Leonardo da Vinci, Einstein, Izaac Newton, Beethoven and Picasso. They all relied on a process known as slow-motion multitasking which in a way relates to conceptual blending and basically means that these creatives combined different concepts and ideas to get inspired. They all had a variety of interests that stimulated them creatively to eventually come up with novel ideas. Why slow-motion? Well, these ideas did not happen overnight, and it was not due to a process of procrastination but rather a process that sometimes even took years.

This doesn't relate to that time you wanted to finish your multiple tasks as soon as possible because you procrastinated but rather to an intentionally slower process of doing multiple tasks simultaneously.

Why does this work?

Incubation effect

Because of a process known as the incubation effect. By doing things simultaneously on and off, like working on a project then taking a break and working on something else, we tend to experience the incubation effect.

What is the incubation effect? It is a process that takes place when you divert your attention away from a given problem or task. Remember that "eureka" moment I referred to earlier? That brilliant idea you got in the shower, while sleeping or doing something else? This is what the incubation effect refers to.

So whenever you're stuck in a creative rut, it is a good idea to divert your attention away from that problem as we tend to focus so much on the problem that your minds become hazy and it is difficult to think of anything else.

Idea generation in graphic design

With all these methods combined, it is possible to generate amazing ideas and concept within the graphic design space. Practicing the creative thinking techniques of conceptual blending as well as the incubation effect allows anyone the ability to come up with amazing concepts and creative ideas.

Hence, creativity is not a talent that only a few selected individuals are born with but can be cultivated by simply practicing creative thinking techniques.

The aim then can be defined as the problem that needs to be solved.

The solution in graphic design can then be to visually communicate effectively.

Understanding this main concept of graphic design, will make the process seem more streamlined and essentially effective visual communication starts with idea generation that takes place within the design cycle's brainstorming phase.

Understanding that idea generation is a learnable skill for everyone, you also need to comprehend that it does not mean that you will feel like a genius because it is a process. Through methodically thinking, our ideas and concepts evolve into something usable and outstanding.

So, understanding that ideas don't just fall from the sky but are rather inspired, this means that we get our ideas for other designs and inspiration during our research & brainstorming phase. YOU WILL ALWAYS BE INFLUENCED BY SOMETHING. Even the greatest designers and inventors were, so stop condemning yourself!

Steer clear of cliches

Another technique to consider is to steer clear of clichés. First, we need to look at what a cliché is. A cliché can be defined as an idea that is unoriginal and overused. Something not unique. This is exactly what a cliché refers to.

The reason why so many people make use of cliché ideas is because their familiarity makes them appealing – it's almost like a guarantee that you won't be misunderstood. In other words, you're playing it safe subconsciously.

Clichés are generally hard to critique because, essentially, there's nothing wrong with them, but they are simply not special.

Clients tend to like clichés but forget that they should rather stand out. It is thus your responsibility as a creative specialist to make sure your client's design conveys the correct message but still stands out. In other words, your design should speak plainly but still leave a mark on its audience.

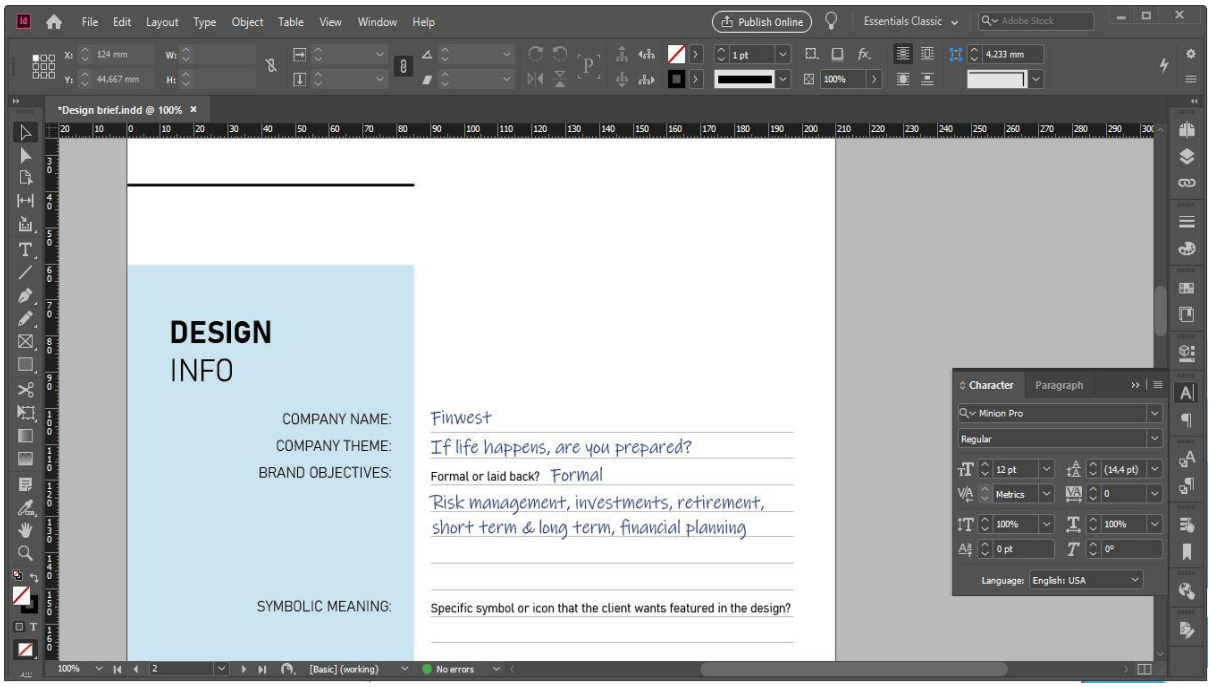
Clichés are like junk food – available everywhere, easy to consume but they don't really have any nutritional value

In order to avoid clichés, you can try the following:

- Make use of a visual riddle. This is where you make use of an element of surprise. Your concept is not too obvious, so you want to spend some time on your design in order to decode the image's message. One trick you can try here is to try and state your message without the use of type.
- Understand that you don't visualise the final design at the start of the design process. It takes time!
- This process entails drawing ideas & inspiration. Draw and write down associations of the subject matter – draw it quickly and don't be critical
- Let clichés happen to get it out of your system as part of the brainstorming phase. This is the evolution of your idea and the starting point might as well be a cliché concept.
- Lastly, when drawing and writing down your ideas, rather make use of a sketch book than a computer. The reason being that a computer has a particular set of tools & this pushes you into a certain direction whereas drawing is free and there are less limits.

I would like to show you a practical example on how these creative techniques were applied to an actual graphic design project.

(Please refer to video lesson)



Conclusion

Let's end off this lesson with a fun exercise. I would like you to create your own personal identity, like in a logo for yourself. We will make use of this logo in our next lesson to expand on our corporate identity. Almost like we did in previous lessons, but this time you have a lot more skills and will be making use of the creative thinking processes you were taught in today's lesson.

You can even compare your logo design skills to the logo you designed previously – afterwards, ask yourself whether there is an improvement.

Ending this mind-blowing lesson from a quote by famous writer George Orwell: To see what is in front of one's nose needs a constant struggle. Amazing ideas will not simply fall from the sky – it never did for anyone.

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